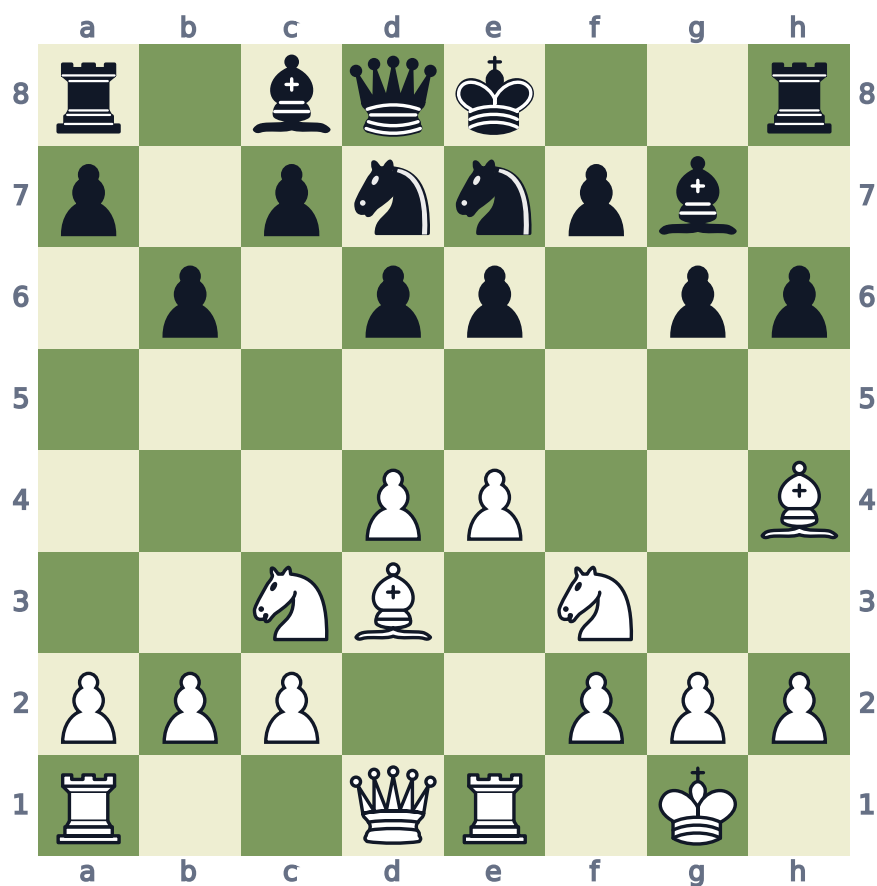


Hippo Piece Maneuvers and Defensive Architecture

Knight routes, bishop diagonals, queen squares, rook files, and purposeful waiting



Turn the compact shell into coordinated piece play, improve the worst piece, and make every waiting move prepare a concrete transformation.

8 learning units | solid-piece diagrams | recall tests | engine checks

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Turn the compact shell into coordinated piece play, improve the worst piece, and make every waiting move prepare a concrete transformation.

THE HIPPO TRAINING LOOP

- First identify the center, both kings, and the opponent's most forcing pawn break.
- At every diagram, name the urgent threat and compare e5, c5, f5, and b5.
- Hide the answer until you have spoken the move, its purpose, and the opponent's best reply.
- Replay each branch from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected Black core repertoire. It teaches setup, exceptions, transformation, and resulting plans; the PGN companions make later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

The e7 knight can reach c6, g6, or f5 depending on the break.

PRINCIPLE 2

The d7 knight supports e5 and c5 but must not permanently block the queen bishop.

PRINCIPLE 3

Bb7 pressures e4 only if the diagonal can actually open.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

Qe8, Qd7, and c7 serve different breaks and king-safety demands.

PRINCIPLE 5

A rook belongs behind the pawn break that is most likely to open a file.

PRINCIPLE 6

A useful waiting move removes an opponent option or improves the coming break.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

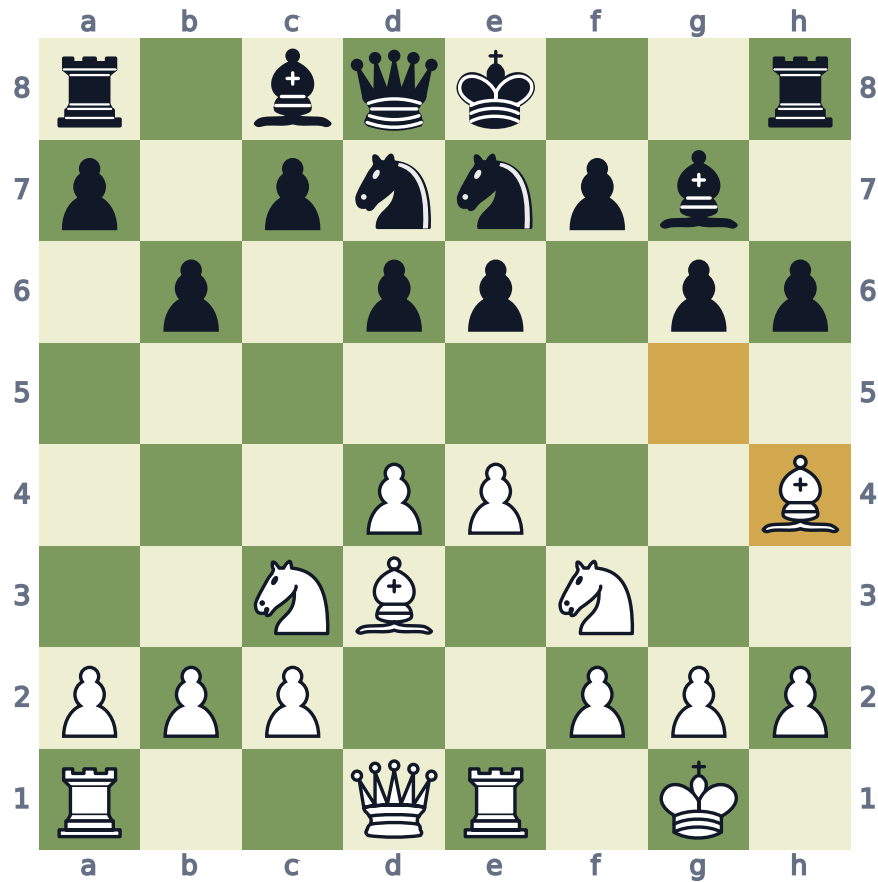
- | | | |
|-----------|--|--|
| 01 | Reroute the e7 knight | The e7 knight needs a destination chosen by the break, not by habit. |
| 02 | Queen on e8 behind e5 or f5 | Qe8 is useful when it supports two plans and does not obstruct the rook. |
| 03 | Rook behind the e-pawn | A rook belongs behind the file your break is likely to open. |
| 04 | Activate Bb7 | Fianchetto the bishop because the diagonal will open, not because the setup says so. |
| 05 | King stays flexible under h-pawn pressure | Flexible king placement expires as soon as the center can open. |
| 06 | Knight route through h3 | Unusual knight routes are justified only by the square they will reach. |
| 07 | Improve the c1 bishop before breaking | Improve the worst piece, then reassess whether the break is ready. |
| 08 | English knight architecture | Compact knights are useful only when the planned break gives them squares. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

Reroute the e7 knight



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7 7. Re1 b6 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

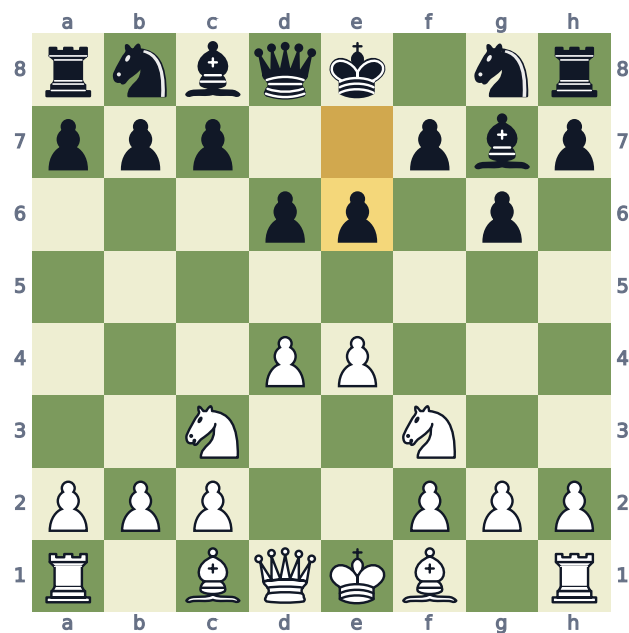
Use h6 to ask the bishop a question and prepare a knight route to f5 or g6.

MAIN DANGER

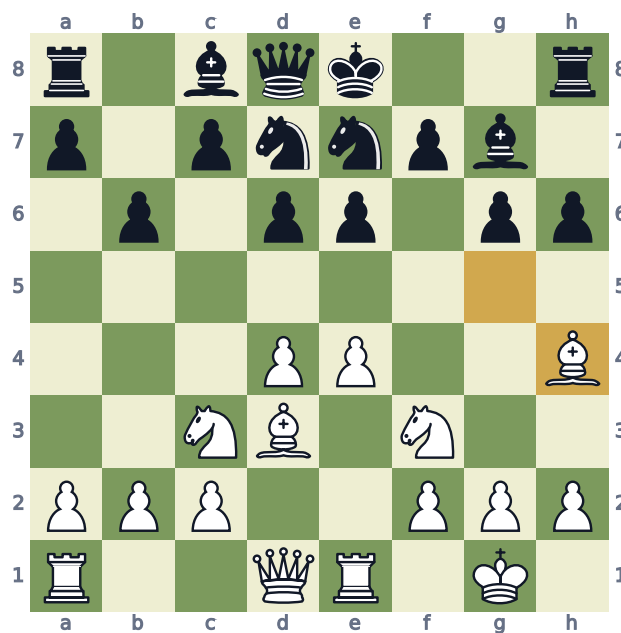
g5 can weaken the king and trap Black's own pieces.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The e7 knight needs a destination chosen by the break, not by habit.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.39 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bb7 Bg3 2. O-O Qe2 3. a6 Rad1 4. b5 e5 5. dxe5 dxe5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

Reroute the e7 knight



YOUR TASK

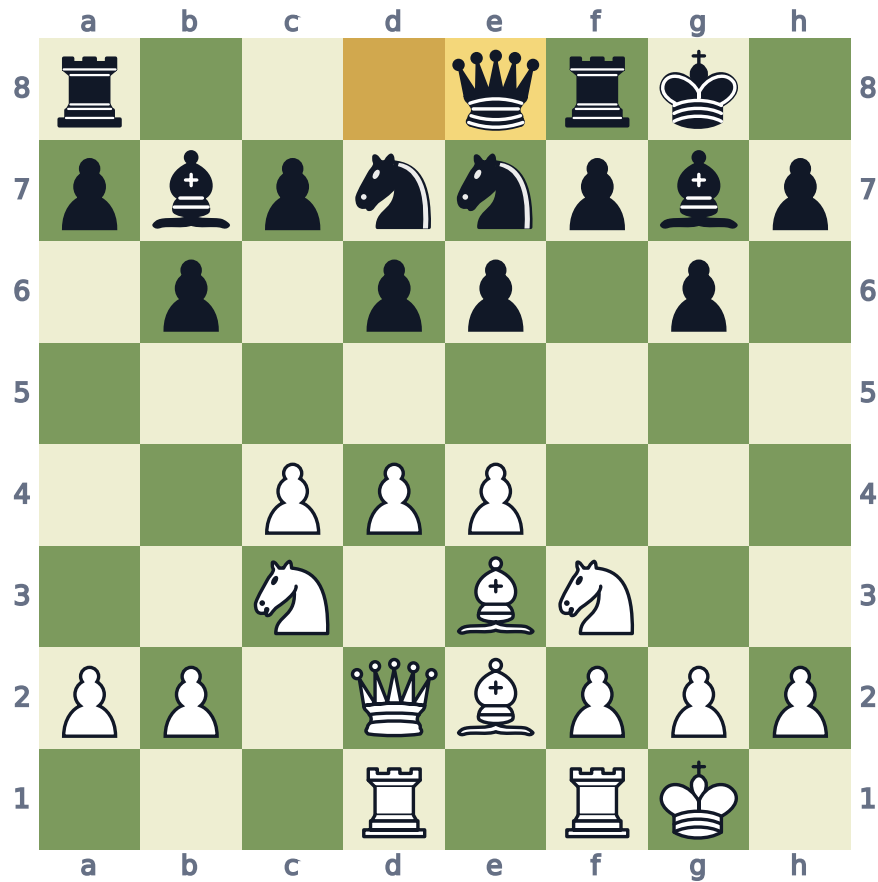
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

Queen on e8 behind e5 or f5



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 Nd7 7. O-O b6 8. Be3 Bb7 9. Qd2 O-O 10. Rad1 Qe8

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Connect the rooks and support e5 or f5 while keeping d8 available.

MAIN DANGER

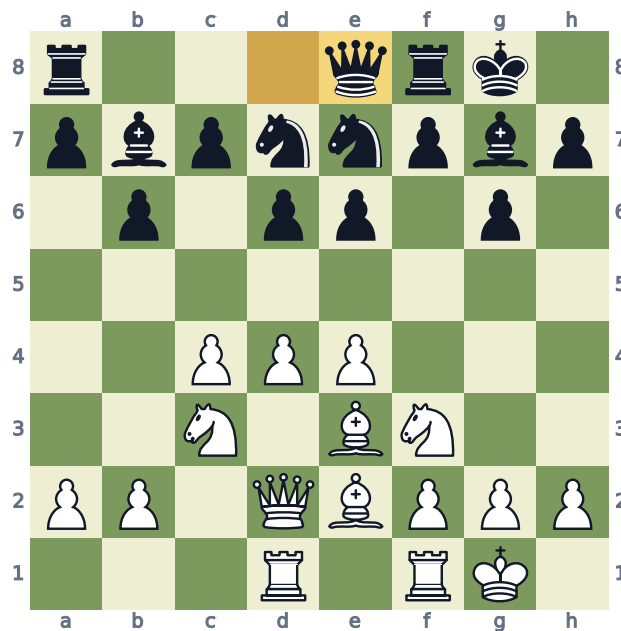
The queen can become exposed on the e-file after exchanges.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 10 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Qe8 is useful when it supports two plans and does not obstruct the rook.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.34 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. h3 a6 2. Rfe1 e5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

Queen on e8 behind e5 or f5



YOUR TASK

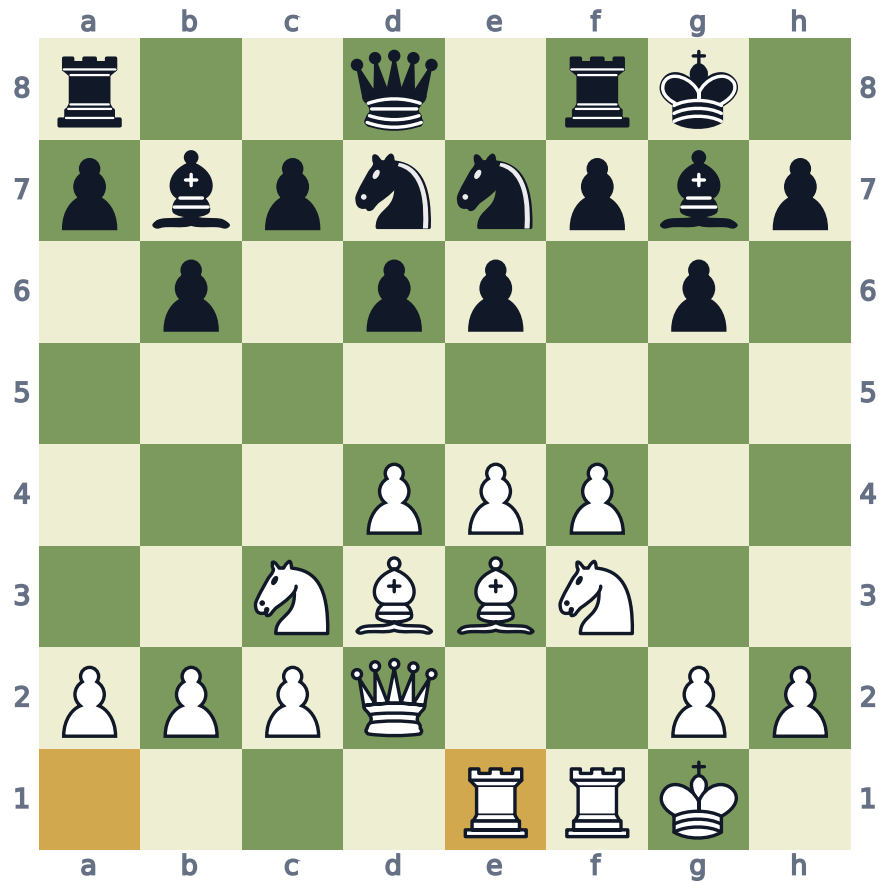
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

Rook behind the e-pawn



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 Nd7 7. O-O b6 8. Be3 Bb7 9. Qd2 O-O 10. Rae1

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Put a rook behind the central contact point and increase the force of e5 ideas.

MAIN DANGER

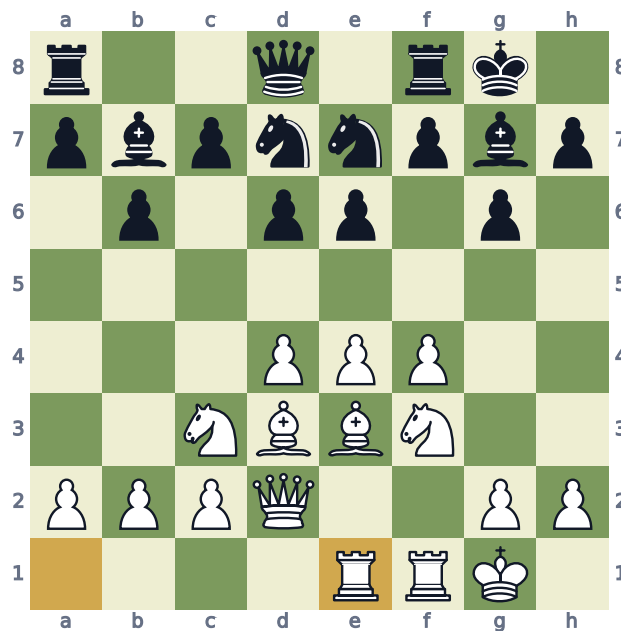
The a-rook move may leave the queenside underdefended.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A rook belongs behind the file your break is likely to open.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.56 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. c5 b3 2. cxd4 Nxd4 3. Nf6 f5 4. e5 Nde2

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

Rook behind the e-pawn



YOUR TASK

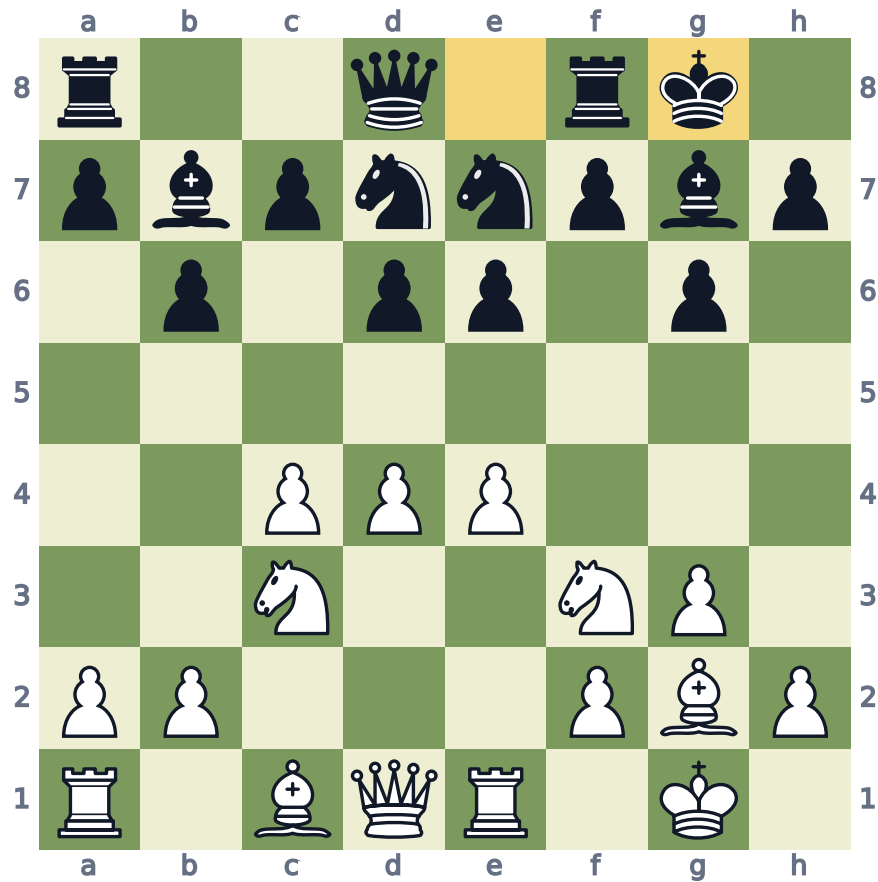
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

Activate Bb7

**COURSE LINE**

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. O-O Ne7 6. c4 Nd7 7. Nc3 b6 8. e4 Bb7 9. Re1 O-O

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

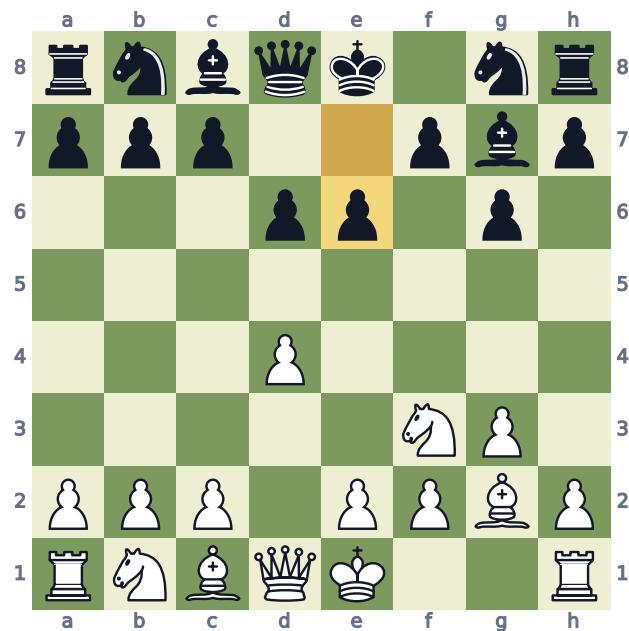
Aim the bishop at e4 and coordinate pressure before playing c5 or e5.

MAIN DANGER

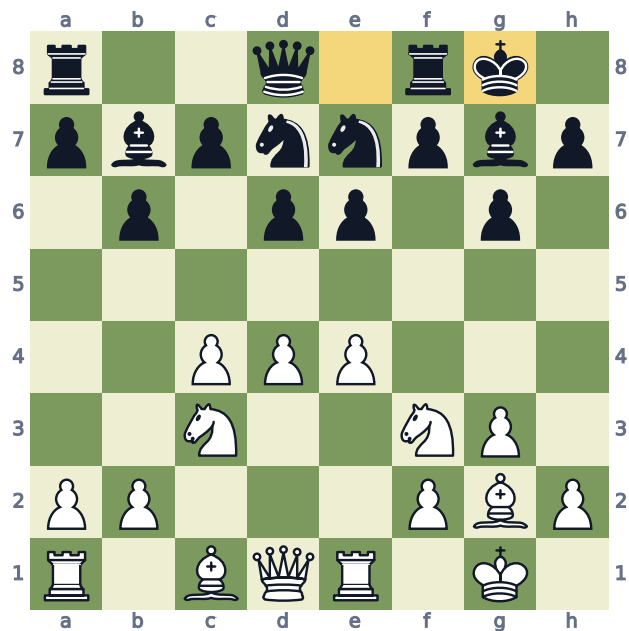
A closed diagonal can make Bb7 a slow spectator.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Fianchetto the bishop because the diagonal will open, not because the setup says so.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

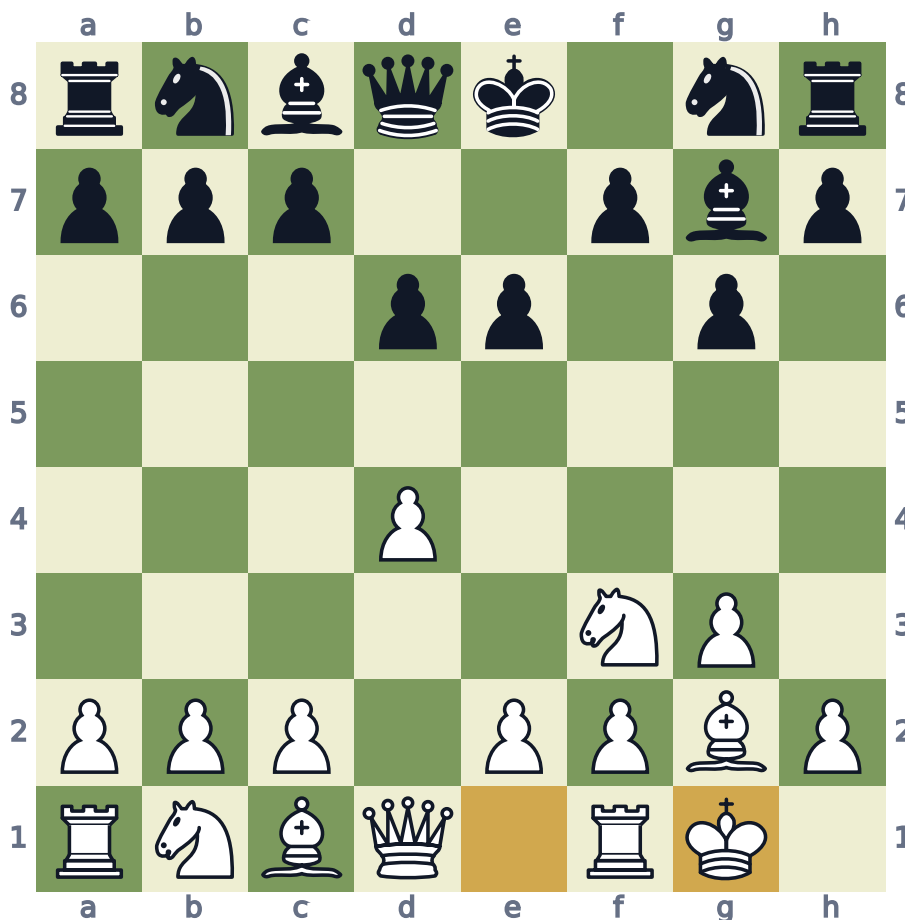
Position estimate: +1.07 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Be3 e5 2. Qd2 c5 3. dxc5 Nxc5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

Activate Bb7



YOUR TASK

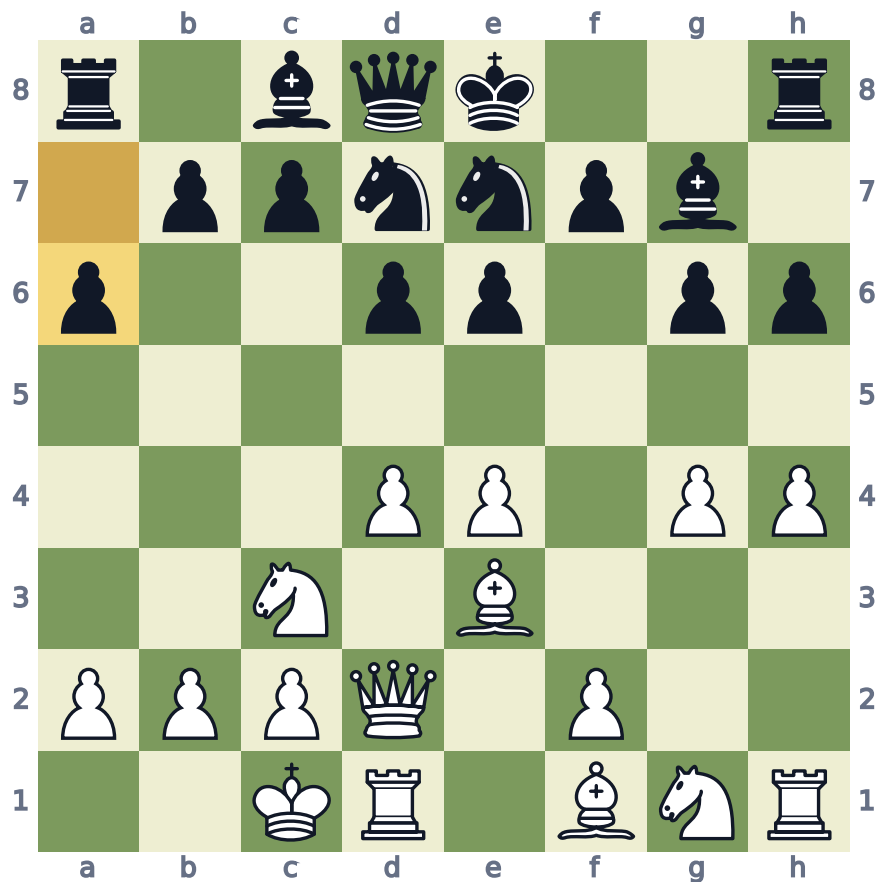
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

King stays flexible under h-pawn pressure



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. h4 h6 5. Be3 e6 6. Qd2 Ne7 7. O-O-O Nd7 8. g4 a6

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

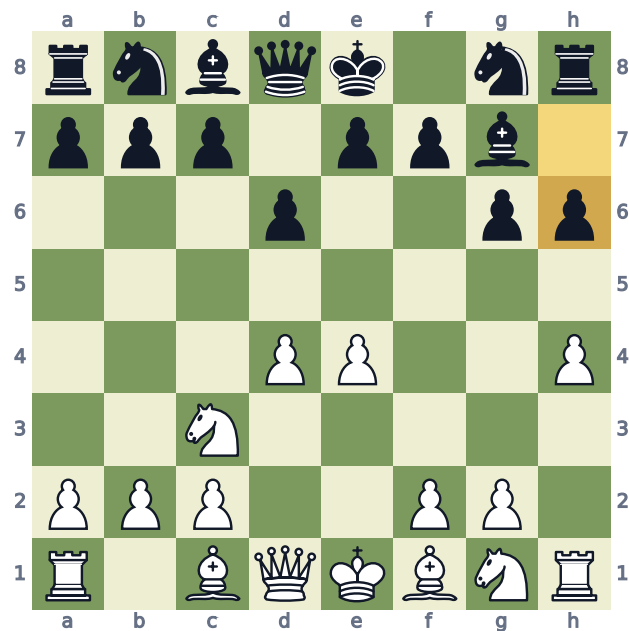
Avoid short castling into an attack and prepare queenside space.

MAIN DANGER

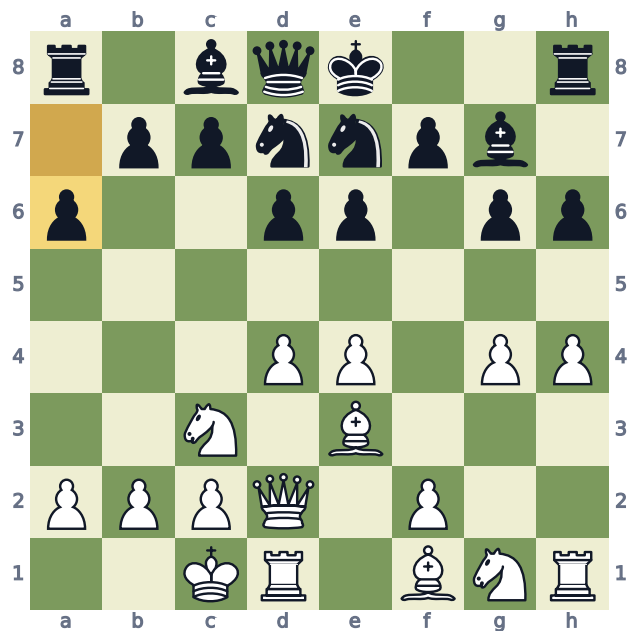
The central king can become vulnerable if e5 opens files.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Flexible king placement expires as soon as the center can open.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.41 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. h5 g5 2. f4 gxf4 3. Bxf4 e5 4. dxe5 Nxe5 5. g5 hxg5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

King stays flexible under h-pawn pressure



YOUR TASK

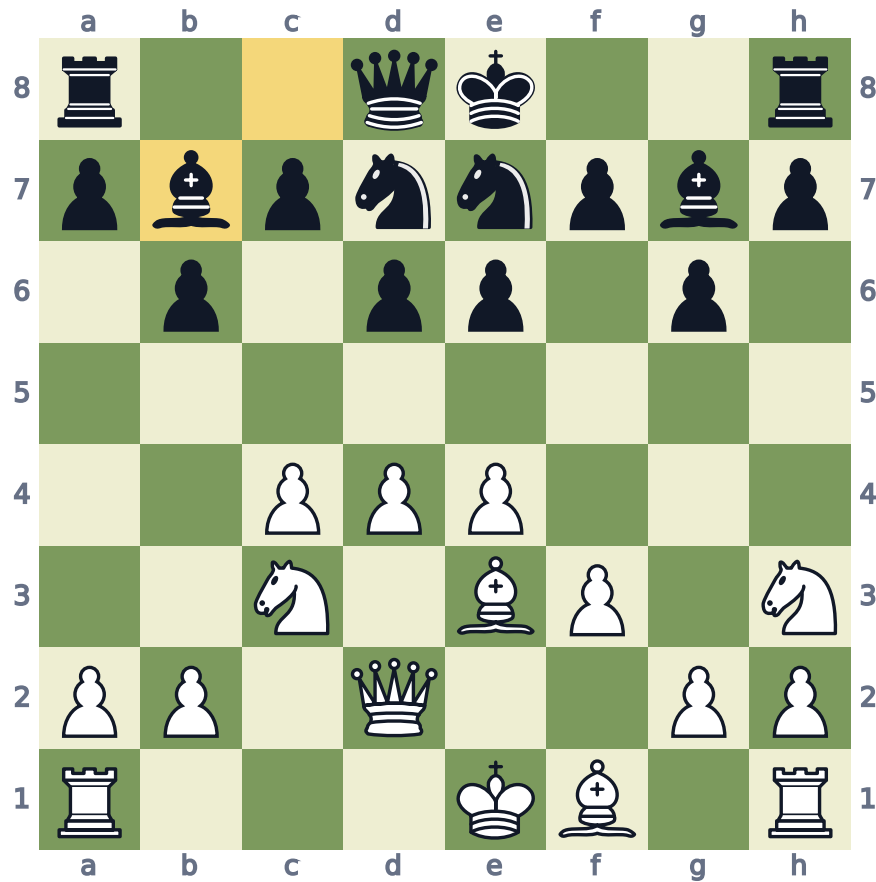
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

Knight route through h3



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Be3 Ne7 6. Qd2 Nd7 7. f3 b6 8. Nh3 Bb7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

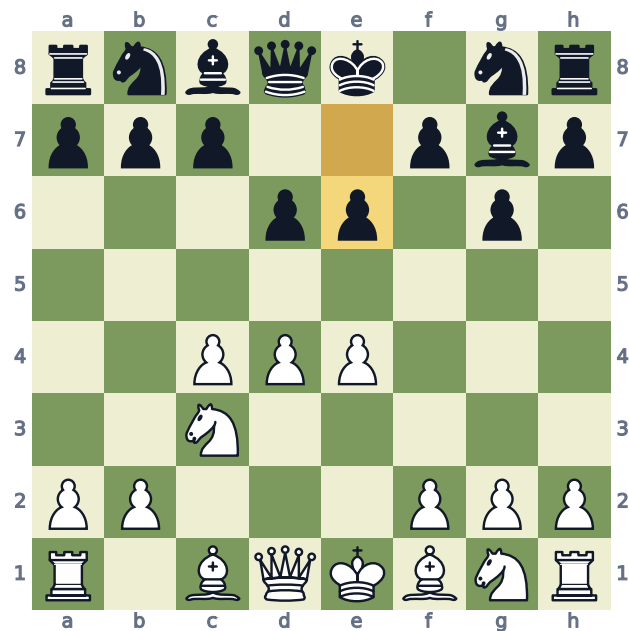
Use h3 to preserve central pawn support and prepare Nf2 or g5.

MAIN DANGER

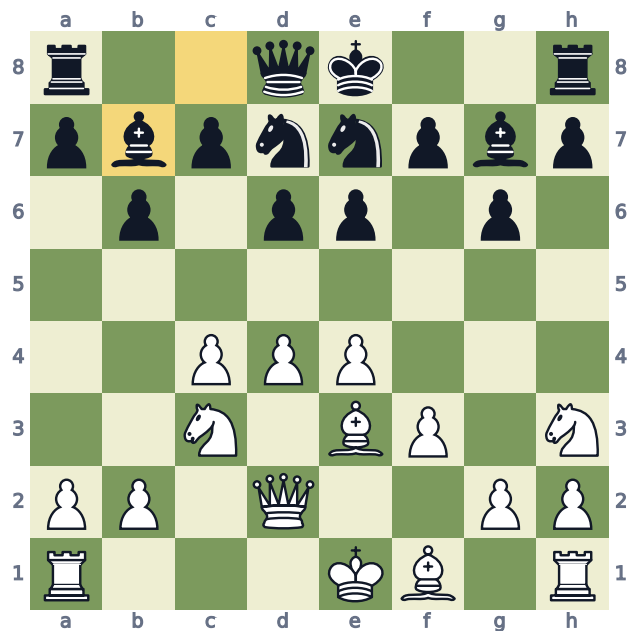
The rim knight may remain irrelevant if the center opens quickly.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Unusual knight routes are justified only by the square they will reach.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

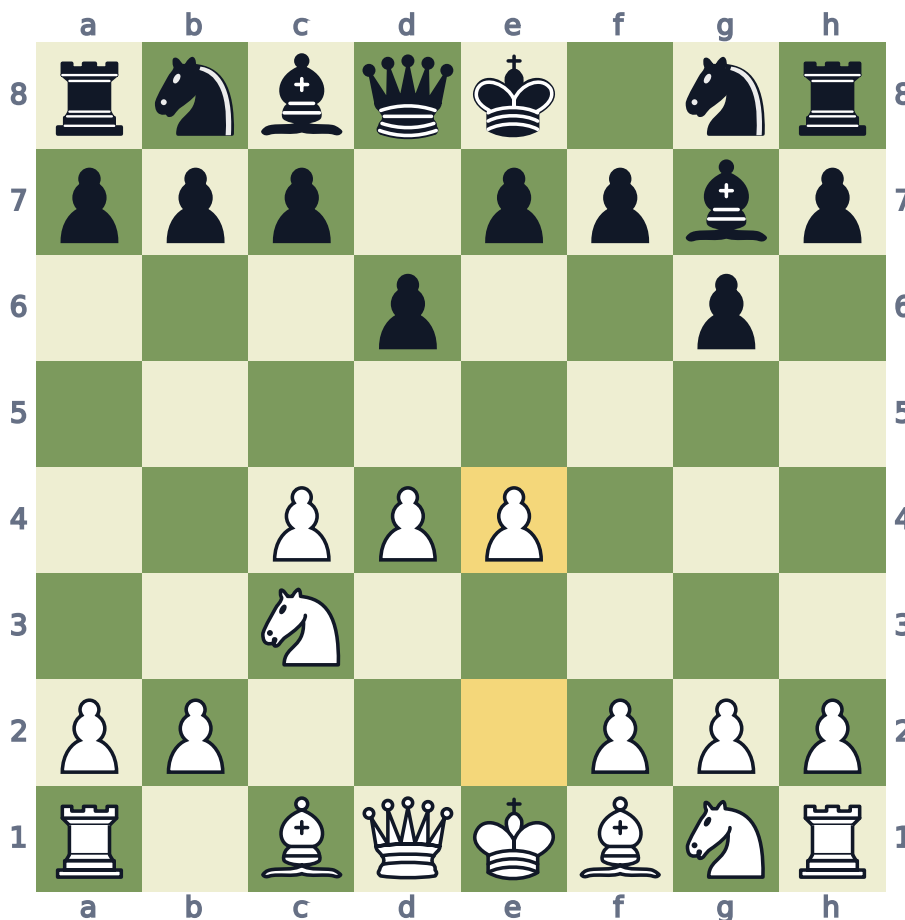
Position estimate: +1.19 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. O-O-O a6 2. d5 exd5 3. cxd5 Rc8 4. Nf2 b5 5. Kb1

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

Knight route through h3



YOUR TASK

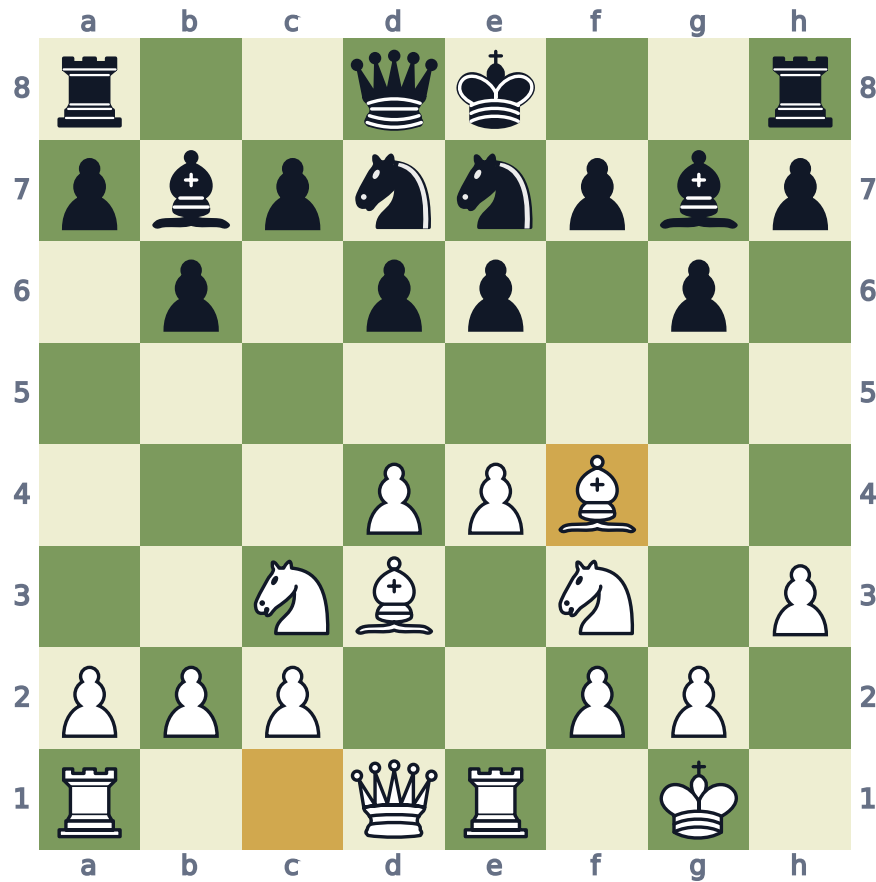
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

Improve the c1 bishop before breaking



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Bf4

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

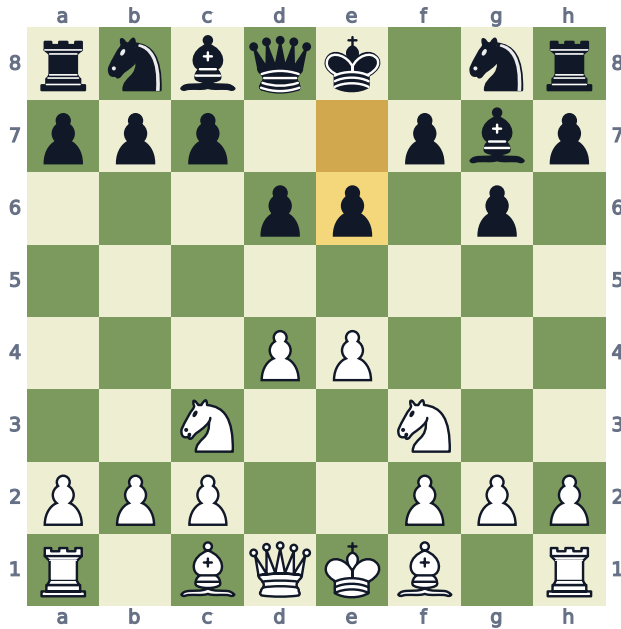
Develop the last piece and increase control of e5 before the center changes.

MAIN DANGER

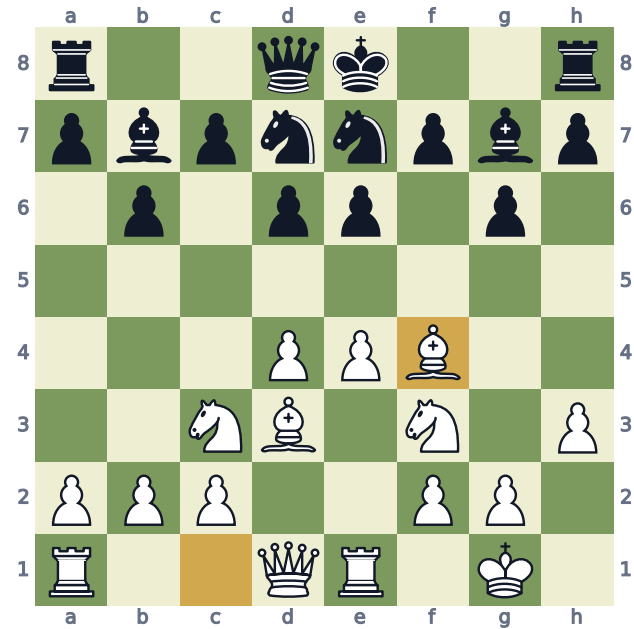
Bf4 can be hit by e5 with tempo if timing is wrong.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Improve the worst piece, then reassess whether the break is ready.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.68 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. O-O Qd2 2. e5 Bh6 3. Nc6 Bg5 4. f6 Bc4+ 5. Kh8 Bh6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

Improve the c1 bishop before breaking



YOUR TASK

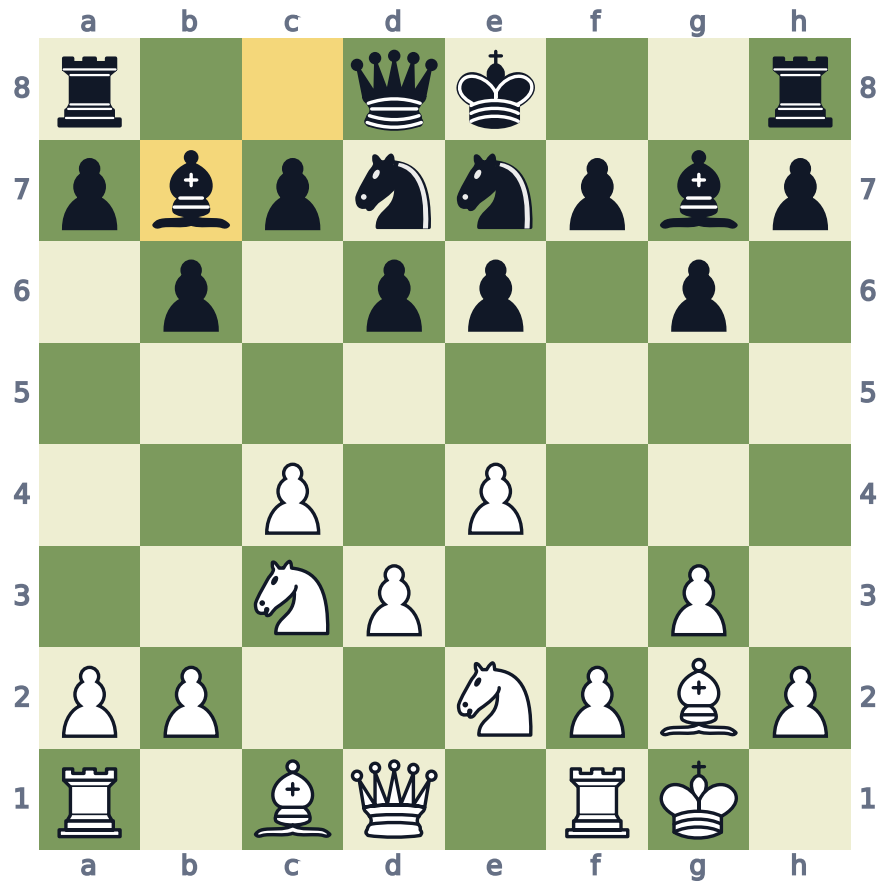
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

English knight architecture



COURSE LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. e4 Nd7 7. Nge2 b6 8. O-O Bb7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

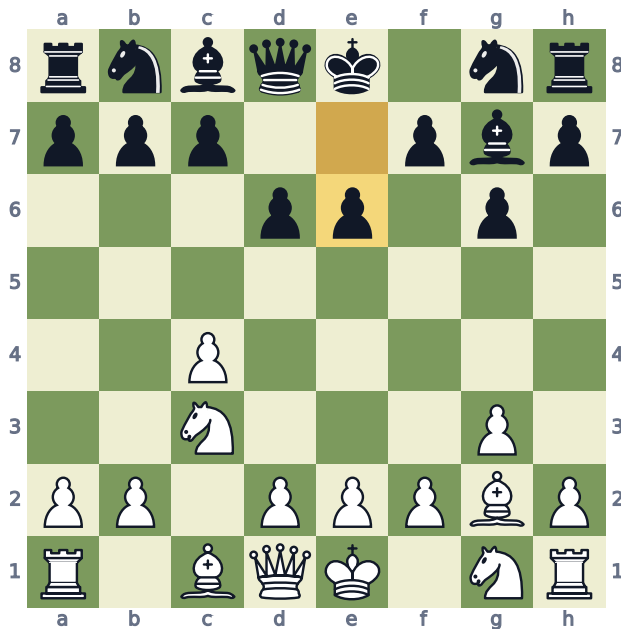
Coordinate both knights around d4, c5, and f5 without blocking the c-pawn.

MAIN DANGER

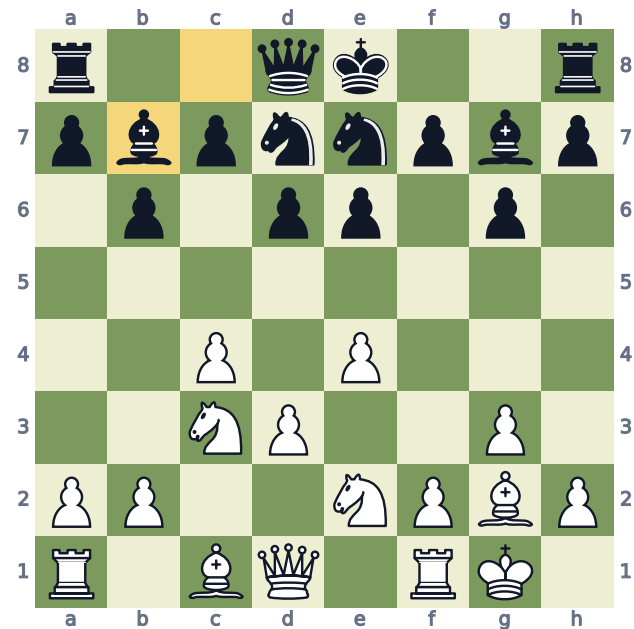
f4-f5 can outrun slow queenside preparation.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Compact knights are useful only when the planned break gives them squares.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

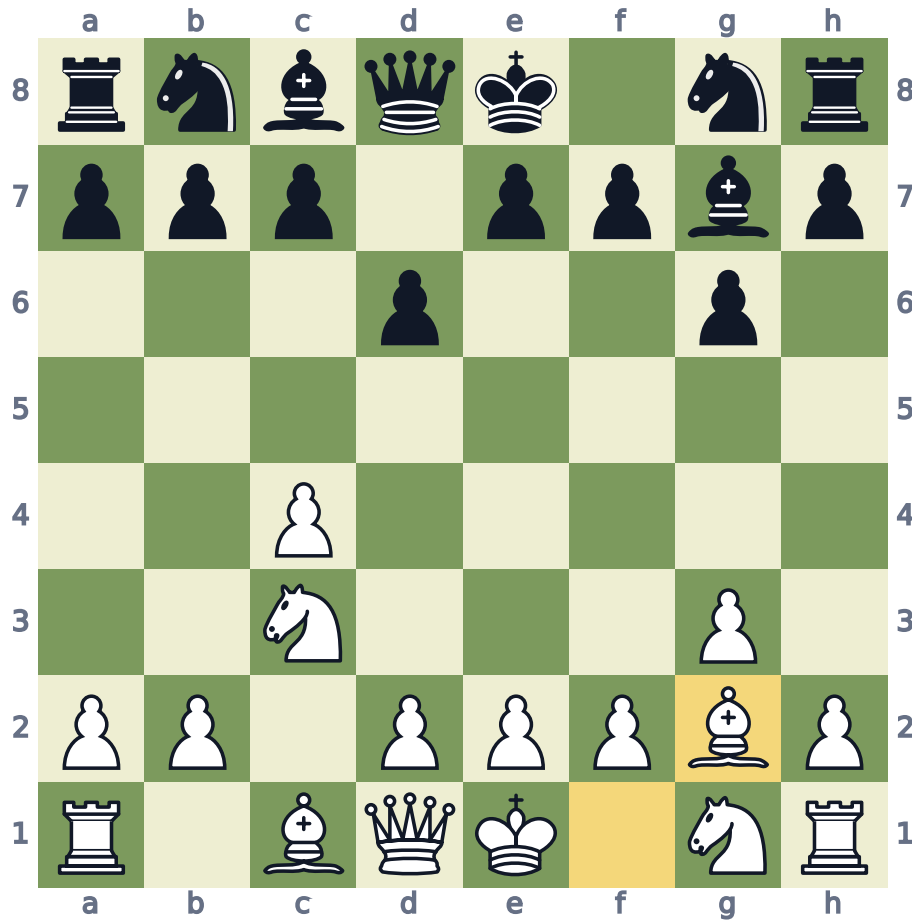
Position estimate: +0.85 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. d4 O-O 2. Be3 c5 3. Qd2 cxd4 4. Bxd4 Ne5 5. b3 N7c6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

English knight architecture



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. REROUTE THE E7 KNIGHT

Course move: e6. Purpose: Use h6 to ask the bishop a question and prepare a knight route to f5 or g6. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be3 2. O-O Qd2 3. Ng4 Bf4 4. c5 dxc5 5. dxc5 h3 (+0.64 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: g5 can weaken the king and trap Black's own pieces.

02. QUEEN ON E8 BEHIND E5 OR F5

Course move: Ne7. Purpose: Connect the rooks and support e5 or f5 while keeping d8 available. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. b6 e5 4. dxe5 Nxe5 5. Nfd7 Bf3 (+0.88 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: The queen can become exposed on the e-file after exchanges.

03. ROOK BEHIND THE E-PAWN

Course move: Ne7. Purpose: Put a rook behind the central contact point and increase the force of e5 ideas. Engine comparison: 1. Nd7 Bd3 2. Ne7 Qe2 3. O-O Be3 4. a6 h4 5. h5 (+0.81 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: The a-rook move may leave the queenside underdefended.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. ACTIVATE BB7

Course move: Ne7. Purpose: Aim the bishop at e4 and coordinate pressure before playing c5 or e5. Engine comparison: 1. Ne7 c4 2. O-O Nc3 3. a6 b3 4. b5 cxb5 5. axb5 Nxb5 (+0.73 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: A closed diagonal can make Bb7 a slow spectator.

05. KING STAYS FLEXIBLE UNDER H-PAWN PRESSURE

Course move: h6. Purpose: Avoid short castling into an attack and prepare queenside space. Engine comparison: 1. h5 Be3 2. c6 Qd2 3. b5 f3 4. a5 Bd3 5. Na6 (+0.53 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The central king can become vulnerable if e5 opens files.

06. KNIGHT ROUTE THROUGH H3

Course move: e6. Purpose: Use h3 to preserve central pawn support and prepare Nf2 or g5. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. e5 d5 4. Na6 Qd2 5. Ng4 Bxg4 (+0.56 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The rim knight may remain irrelevant if the center opens quickly.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. IMPROVE THE C1 BISHOP BEFORE BREAKING

Course move: e6. Purpose: Develop the last piece and increase control of e5 before the center changes. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be3 2. O-O Qd2 3. Ng4 Bf4 4. c5 dxc5 5. dxc5 h3 (+0.64 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Bf4 can be hit by e5 with tempo if timing is wrong.

08. ENGLISH KNIGHT ARCHITECTURE

Course move: e6. Purpose: Coordinate both knights around d4, c5, and f5 without blocking the c-pawn. Engine comparison: 1. Nc6 Rb1 2. a5 d3 3. Nf6 h3 4. O-O a3 5. e6 (+0.34 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: f4-f5 can outrun slow queenside preparation.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.